Rajasthan has six forts which are World Heritage Sites, cited by UNESCO as 'Hill Forts of Rajasthan'. The eclectic architecture of the forts, some up to 20 kilometres in circumference, bears testimony to the power of the Rajput princely states that flourished in the region from the 8th to the 18th centuries

is extremely impressive. Flanked by public gardens, the Doodh Talai stepwell in Udaipur is a serene spot. Panna Meena Ka Kund in Amer, Hadi Rani ki Baori in Tonk, Jachcha ki Baori in Hindaun, and Bhooton ki Baoli in Ransi are some other stepwells of note in Rajasthan.

Ajmer

Ajmer was founded in the 7th century by Raja Ajai Pal Chauhan, a green oasis surrounded by barren hills. The Dargah of Sufi saint Khwaja Moinuddin Chishti here is one of the most important pilgrim centres in India. Just beyond the Dargah is the Adhai-din-ka-Jhonpra, a masterpiece of Indo-Islamic architecture. A steep half-hour climb from here is the Taragarh Fort, which offers excellent views of the city. The Ana Sagar-Baradari is a charming artificial lake created by Arno Raj Chauhan in the 12th century. The white marble baradari or pavilions were built by Shah Jahan. The holy town of Pushkar is close to Ajmer.

Alwar

Strategically located midway between Delhi and Jaipur, Alwar has an ancient history. It was once part of the Matsya Kingdom, one of the 16 Mahajanapadas of ancient India. In medieval times it was ruled by a number of Rajput clans before being established as a princely state in 1770. The imposing Alwar Fort sits 304 metres above the city, its ramparts stretching five kilometres from north to south and 1.6 kilometres from east to west. The 18th-century City Palace is a harmonious blend of Rajput and Mughal styles of architecture. The Jai Samand Lake is just six kilometres away and a great spot for picnics.

Bharatpur

This is the region where the Matsya kingdom once flourished. The origin of the name Bharatpur is traced to Bharat, younger brother of Lord Ram. In the early 18th century, Maharaja Suraj Mal captured the fort of Bharatpur and laid the foundation for Bharatpur. He also built the pleasure palaces of Deeg. Bharatpur is also home to one of the world's best-known bird watching destinations, Keoladeo Ghana National Park. The Bharatpur Palace is home to Kamra Khas, a museum that contains a vast number of antiques, stone sculptures, local art and craft wares and ancient scriptures that depict the art and culture typical of Bharatpur. Ganga Mandir and Laxman Mandir are two of the most prominent temples here. Radiating an aura of rugged strength is the Lohagarh Fort. The beautiful garden town of Deeg is situated north of Bharatpur. It is known for its forts, palaces, gardens and fountains.

Bikaner

The Rathore prince Rao Bikaji, son of the founder of Jodhpur, established Bikaner in 1488. The city was once a great trade centre given its strategic location on the ancient caravan routes of West and Central Asia.

The old city of Bikaner sits on slightly raised ground encircled by battlements with five gates. Built in 1588 by Raja Rai Singh, the Junagarh Fort here is an impressive structure surrounded by a moat and containing some beautiful palaces. Notable palaces include Chandra Mahal with its paintings, mirrors and carved panels, while the ornate Phool Mahal has mirror work and stucco motifs. The Suraj Pol or Sun Gate is the main entrance to the fort. There is also a museum here which will enthrall archaeology enthusiasts.

Kota

Set on the banks of the Chambal River, Kota is famed for its distinctive style of paintings, palaces, museums, and places of worship. Now an education hub which attracts students from all over the country, it is also known for its Doria saris and Kota kachoris. Kota was carved out as an independent state from Bundi in 1631. Today, it is a city of gardens, palaces, and temples. Its best-known attraction is the Garh Palace, a sprawling complex of suites and apartments built by different Rajput rulers. Within its walls lies the Maharao Madho Singh Museum, boasting a splendid collection of Rajput miniature paintings of the Kota school. The Jagmandir Palace was built by one of the queens of Kota in 1743-45 and sits in the middle of Kishore Sagar Lake. Prominent temples in the vicinity include the Karni Mata Temple and Dad Devi Temple.

Bundi

Bundi is a picturesque town with intricately carved havelis and palaces, temples with beautiful idols, and a lovely lake. Built in 1354, Bundi's Taragarh Fort is one of the most impressive in Rajasthan. The Palace is a fine example of Rajput architecture, with some superb murals on its walls. The Chhattar Mahal or Palace of Towers can be reached via a steep carriageway and contains impressive structures. The most famous attraction in Bundi is the Chitrashala, a pavilion and gallery of miniature murals embellishing the palace.

Jhalawar

Jhalawar sits at the edge of the Malwa Plateau in a rocky yet verdant landscape. This princely state of the Jhalas was founded in 1838 after being cleaved off from Kota by the British. The impressive Garh Palace in the centre of town was built in the founding year and features some exquisite paintings and mirrors on the walls of the Zanana Khas. The upper part of Garh Palace houses the Government Museum. The Bhawani Natya Shala in Jhalawar has to be the most unusual theatre in India.

